Participation from the target audience for the specific media or release is a very critical requirement. And because this typically comes through the common project resources, it also means that the people doing this work are well engaged in the core project scope and Linux distribution areas, allowing them to bridge the two sides nicely.

At the moment, there are dozens of different kinds of CentOS releases, including atomic hosts, minimal installs, DVD ISOs, cloud images, vagrant images and containers. Each of these comes through a group that is well invested in the specific space.

Q What are the various efforts that lead to a consistent developer experience on CentOS Linux?

Application developers working to consume CentOS Linux as their base can trust the API/ABI efforts where content deployed today will still work three or five years down the road. The interfaces into that don't change (they can evolve, but won't break existing content/scripts/code). Therefore, working with these interfaces also means that they work within the same process that the end user is already aware of and already manages for simple things like security patching, an area often overlooked by the casual developer.

Q How does the small team of developers manage to offer a long period of support for every single release?

We invest heavily in automation to enable long-term support. And that means that a very small group of people can actually look after a very large codebase. It changes the scope of what the contributors need to do. Rather than working on the code process, we work on the automation around it, and aggressively test and monitor the process and code.

The other thing is that we get community support. Developers and contributors don't always have the time to work on each request, but if you look at the CentOS Forums, almost every question gets a great result.

There is also a lot of diversity in the groups. The CentOS IRC channel idles at over 600 users during the day, but a large number of users never visit the forums. Similarly, the CentOS mailing lists include over 50,000 people, but a large number of them are never reaching the IRC channel or the forums.

> "*We invest heavily in automation to enable long-term support.*"

Q Is it solely the community feedback that helps you build new CentOS updates, or do you also consider feature requests from the Red Hat team?

CentOS Linux is built as a downstream from Red Hat's sources. They are being delivered via *git.centos.org*, and then the additional layers and packages are built by various community members. We also encourage people to come and join the development process to build, test and deliver features to the audience that we target through the open source project. All this is entirely community focused.

So if someone at Red Hat wants to execute something, they would need to join the relevant community and work that route for engagement on CentOS.

Having said that, we have a concept of Special Interest Groups that can be started by anyone, with a specific target in mind. Of course, this is only above the Linux distribution itself.

Q Apart from your engagements related to being a CentOS Project member, what are your major tasks at Red Hat?

These days, I spend around 30 per cent of my time working on the CentOS Project. Rather than in the project itself, most of my focus is around enablement and making sure that contributors and developers have the resources they need to succeed. The other 70 per cent of my time is spent as a consulting engineer at Red Hat, working with service teams, helping build best practices in operations roles and modern system patterns for online services.

Additionally, I have been involved in some of the work going on in the containers world and its user stores, which includes DevOps, SRE-Patterns, CI and CD, among others.

Q What are the major differences you've observed being a part of a corporate entity like Red Hat and a community member? Which is tougher among the two?

I have been involved with open source communities for over 15 years. During such a long period, open source work has never been my primary job. It's always been something that I do in my free time or in addition to what I was already doing, similar to my move with the CentOS Project. But what makes Red Hat unique in a way is that this isn't an odd role.

A large number of people at Red Hat participate and execute their day job via open source communities. And that makes it a lot easier, being a long-term contributor.

There is only one key challenge that one needs to keep in mind when working on an open source project as a part of the day job, though. It is to set realistic expectations around community participation, and recognise that the community is there because its members often care about something far more than the people paid to work on a project. However, this typically isn't a concern when a community comes together around smaller pieces of the code.

The CentOS Project has quite a widespread and extensive footprint. It involves talking to and participating in a wider community where a large majority is unknown personally. Managing expectations and ensuring